PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

The Election of 1860 — House & Divided

How the Numbers Elected Lincoln

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about The Election of 1860 — House & Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Numbers are a primary source too. Read the 1860 returns and the campaign cartoons, then explain how the math worked

THE SOURCES

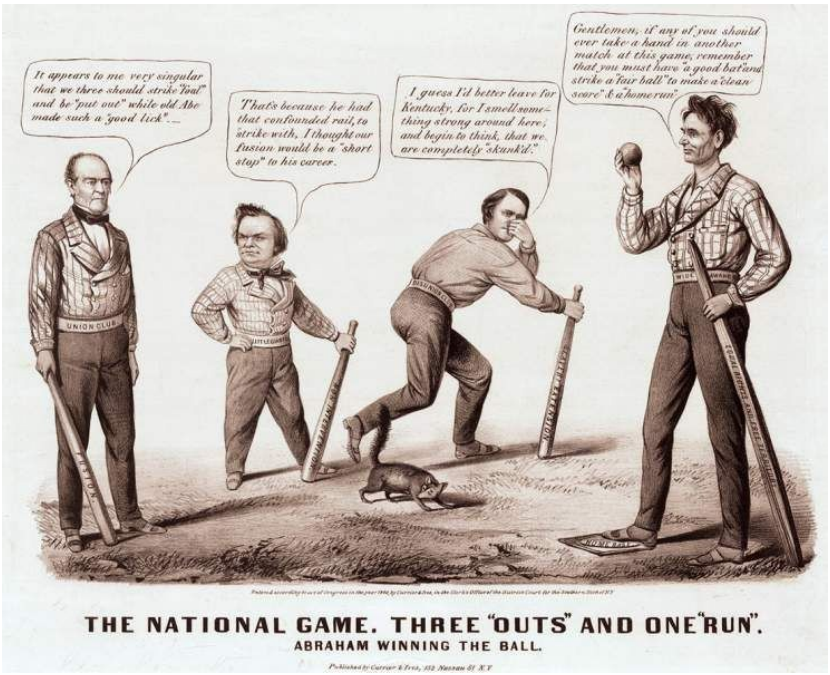
SOURCE A · THE DATA · 1860 — The returns

#activity .rtab{width:100%;border-collapse:collapse;margin:8px 0 2px;font-size:14.5px}
#activity .rtab th,#activity .rtab td{border:1px solid var(--hair);padding:9px 12px;text-align:left;color:var(--body)}
#activity .rtab th{color:var(--accent);text-transform:uppercase;letter-spacing:.06em;font-size:11.5px}
#activity .rtab td.n{text-align:right;font-variant-numeric:tabular-nums;color:var(--ink)}
#activity .rtab tr.win td{background:rgba(224,128,95,.1)}

CANDIDATE	PARTY	REGION OF SUPPORT	POPULAR VOTE	%	ELECTORAL
Abraham Lincoln	Republican	North / West	1,866,000	40%	180
Stephen Douglas	Northern Democrat	scattered, North	1,380,000	29%	12
John C. Breckinridge	Southern Democrat	Deep South	848,000	18%	72
John Bell	Constitutional Union	Border South	591,000	13%	39.

Election of 1860 returns (rounded). 152 electoral votes were needed to win. Public-domain data.

SOURCE B · THE CARTOON — “The National Game”



"The National Game. Three 'Outs' and One 'Run'" — Currier & Ives, 1860, public domain (Library of Congress).

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · READ THE TABLE

Lincoln won only about 40% of the popular vote — less than the other three combined. So how did he win the election? (Look at the electoral-vote column.)

_____

_____

_____

QUESTION 2 STEP 1 · READ THE TABLE

Douglas came 2nd in the popular vote (29%) but won only 12 electoral votes — far fewer than Breckinridge's 72 on just 18%. What does that tell you about where each man's votes were?

_____

_____

_____

QUESTION 3 STEP 2 · A SECTIONAL MAP

Lincoln carried the free North; Breckinridge swept the Deep South; Lincoln wasn't even on most Southern ballots. What does this pattern reveal?

- ☐ A. that most Americans agreed on the issues

☐ B. that the nation was already dividing into two separate political regions

☐ C. that the election was fraudulent

☐ D. that slavery was no longer an issue

QUESTION 4 STEP 3 · WHY IT MATTERED

Lincoln promised only to stop slavery from spreading, not to end it in the South. So why did his election — a fair, legal election — convince the South to leave the Union? Answer in two or three sentences.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — The Election of 1860 — House & Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Lincoln won because, even with 40%, his electoral votes..."

QUESTION 2: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Douglas's votes were spread thin across many states, while Breckinridge's were..."

QUESTION 3: **Correct — B. that the nation was already dividing into two separate political regions**

Exactly. The vote didn't split by candidate so much as by region. The country was no longer arguing as one nation — it was already voting as two.

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "The South left because the election proved..."